

MIT News: One ChatGPT query uses 5x the energy of a Google search. By 2026, AI data centers will consume more electricity than Japan.

Posted by u/EchoOfOppenheimer • 0 points • 19 comments

MIT researchers detail the staggering environmental footprint of Generative AI. Beyond the well-known energy costs of training (where one model can consume enough power for 120 homes), the article highlights that **inference**, actual daily use, is the bigger threat.

Comments

u/redhotcigarbutts • 1 points • 2026-01-16 22:05 UTC

And that's just for the query let alone all the other consumption for training etc.

u/y2kobserver • 1 points • 2026-01-15 00:32 UTC

Yeah but you need 40 google searches for some stuff AI can just do in one go

u/MarkoMarjamaa • 1 points • 2026-01-14 12:46 UTC

I think last year it was 10x?

u/Beautiful-Fig7824 • 1 points • 2026-01-13 20:54 UTC

1 minute of using a space heater uses 80x more energy than 1 Google search.

One Google search = ~ 0.0003 kWh (≈ 0.3 Wh)

One minute of running a 1.5 kW heater = ~ 0.025 kWh (≈ 25 Wh)

u/allupya333 • 1 points • 2026-01-13 05:51 UTC

this is a year old prediction that is just completely wrong

u/DistributionRight261 • 1 points • 2026-01-12 18:37 UTC

What about the new neural chips Google is working on?

u/Actual__Wizard • 1 points • 2026-01-12 19:57 UTC

If it's coming from their one subsidiary company, it's probably vapor ware. Which chip?

u/DistributionRight261 • 1 points • 2026-01-13 05:15 UTC

As of early 2026, Google TPUs and NVIDIA GPUs remain the two leading hardware platforms for AI workloads, with TPUs excelling in large-scale, inference-optimized environments and GPUs maintaining dominance in flexibility, ecosystem breadth, and mixed workloads. Recent developments highlight that while NVIDIA's Blackwell GPUs lead in raw performance and developer tooling, Google's TPU Trillium and Ironwood generations offer superior cost efficiency for high-volume inference, particularly within Google Cloud.

(AI generated summary)